regions of Spiti and Ladakh in India maintained strong ecclesiastical relations with Ngari, Tholing and Purang in western Tibet. Some of these links have survived into contemporary times.

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The history of western Tibet after the age of empire ended in the ninth century is relevant to the India–China border issue. When the Tibetan empire began to fragment, one of the local princes, Kyide Nimagon, broke away to establish his own kingdom in western Tibet. This kingdom comprised three distinct zones – the Zanskar, Maryul and Guge regions. Maryul is what we now know as Ladakh. Kailash–Mansarovar, which is sacred both to Hindus and Buddhists, is located in the Guge region. Ladakh emerged as an independent kingdom under the Namgyal dynasty in the fifteenth century with its capital at Leh. It incorporated Zanskar and later Baltistan into the kingdom. It patronized the Red Hat or the Drukpa sect, which had been propagated by the Indian sage Naropa in the tenth century. During extended periods of turmoil in Tibet, a number of Buddhist monks from the country found refuge in Bhutan. It was under Shabdrung Nawang Namgyal, who hailed from western Tibet but was related to the Namgyal family ruling in Leh, that the place we now know as Bhutan was consolidated as a state in the southern Himalayas in the seventeenth century. The state of Sikkim also came to be ruled by another branch of the Namgyal family around the same time.

When Tibet under the fifth Dalai Lama attacked Ladakh in 1679, its rulers were already paying tribute to the Mughal emperor. The neighbouring state of Kashmir had come under Mughal rule in 1578. Mughal protection enabled the Namgyals to resist the Tibetan onslaught, but in return the then Mughal emperor, Aurangzeb, insisted on a mosque being built in Leh and Islam being introduced in the kingdom. Part of the population of Ladakh became Muslim.

A treaty was concluded between Ladakh and Tibet in 1684, known as the Tingmosgang treaty, through which a boundary was drawn between them by referring to various geographical features along the agreed alignment. It